

HISTORY HACK · DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

Read the following two primary source excerpts and answer the prompt below.

US.38 — Describe the Scopes Trial of 1925, including the major figures (i.e., John Scopes, William Jennings Bryan, and Clarence Darrow), two sides of the controversy (i.e., fundamentalism and modernism), the outcome, and the legacy.

Name _____ Class _____ Date _____

The sources

Document A

William Jennings Bryan, closing statement prepared for the Scopes Trial, Dayton, Tennessee, 1925 (Bryan never delivered this statement — the trial ended before the defense rested — but it was published posthumously in *Memoirs of William Jennings Bryan*, 1925, public domain)

“The real issue is not what is true in science, but whether teachers paid by the taxpayers shall be permitted to undermine the religious faith of the children of those taxpayers... I am not making any argument against the truth of evolution. I am arguing against the right of evolutionists to demand pay for teaching that which is offensive to those who pay the taxes.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT A

H — Historical context

What was happening when this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how does that shape it?

Document B

Clarence Darrow, closing argument in the Scopes Trial, Rhea County Circuit Court, Dayton, Tennessee, July 1925 (trial transcript, public domain, Library of Congress)

“If today you can take a thing like evolution and make it a crime to teach it in the public schools, tomorrow you can make it a crime to teach it in the private schools, and next year you can make it a crime to teach it to the hustings or in the church. At the next session you may ban books and the newspapers. Ignorance and fanaticism are ever busy and ever in need of fresh victories. Whenever they are stopped they must be stopped or they will pile on ignorance upon ignorance and fanaticism on fanaticism, until we shall all find ourselves in the very darkness of the middle ages.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT B

H — Historical context

What was happening when this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or hear it?

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What was it trying to make the audience do or think?

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Who is speaking, and how does that shape it?

The question

Both of these arguments were made in Dayton, Tennessee during the 1925 Scopes Trial. Using BOTH documents and your knowledge of the Scopes Trial (US.31) and cultural tensions of the 1920s (US.33), write a multi-paragraph response that applies HIPP to each document and constructs an argument about the fundamental values in conflict at the Scopes Trial and why this conflict mattered beyond Dayton, Tennessee. Your response must analyze each document using all four HIPP elements, explain what each author believed was truly at stake, and use outside knowledge to assess the lasting significance of this Tennessee trial for American constitutional history.

Plan your answer

Your claim	
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Source	Evidence you will use	Why it supports your claim
Document A		
Document B		
Outside knowledge		

Write your response

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